The motivation for creating the Taj may still be an open question, but ultimately, it was the Mughal Empire and its Persian influences that made the Taj Mahal possible by creating a cultural context that made the monument a synthesis of Muslim, Persian, and Hindu architecture.

The Mughals were one of the great dynastic empires of the early Modern period, competing with the Shahs of Persia and the Ottomans of Istanbul for the title of the greatest Muslim-ruled state of its time. Like the dynasties of both of these other empires, the Mughals were descendants of nomadic Central Asian tribes that traced their ancestry to both the Mongol Khans (where their name "Mughal" originates) and the Turkic tribes. For example, the first Mughal Emperor Babur (r. 1526-1530) claimed a lineage on his mother's side from Genghis Khan's second son Chagatai and the great Turkic leader Timur on his father's side. Driven from the steppes, Babur established a base in the city of Kabul (today the capital of Afghanistan), and from there he conquered south and east over much of today's Pakistan and northern India, including the populous areas of Punjab and then over the Sultan of Delhi[5]. Throughout the two centuries and seven emperors of the Mughal dynasty, the realm was known for its able administrators, distinctive architecture, and its relative religious harmony.

After Babur, perhaps the best known emperor was Akbar the Great, who ruled from 1556-1605, a reign of considerable length. Under the rule of Akbar, the Mughal court was known for its religious tolerance, and the non-Muslim majorities of his realm (primarily Hindus) were fully integrated into the intellectual and political life of the empire. In fact, Akbar promoted a new religion of his own creation called Din-e-Illahi, which fused Islam and Hinduism with elements of Christianity and Zoroastrianism. While Din-e-Illahi may have been a personality cult around the Emperor that never had widespread acceptance and all but died with him, it did reveal the Mughal emperor's willingness to adapt his Islamic background to an Indian context.[6]

In addition to its adoption of indigenous cultural traits, the Mughal court also borrowed heavily from neighboring Persia, even though the Persians were rivals of the Mughals. In fact, they battled over the territory of today's Afghanistan, and the great Persian emperor Nader Shah eventually sacked Delhi and stole Shah Jahan's dazzling Peacock Throne in 1639. Nevertheless, the Persians were the dominant cultural power of southern Asia at the time,